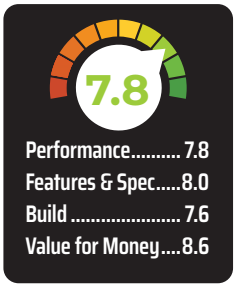
CMF Buds Neo

Enjoyable sound, good ANC, and impressive value

₹2,199



Even on a strictly tight budget, you can find some really good earbuds these days. Unlike phones and laptops, there haven't suddenly gotten super expensive amidst the chip shortages and the memory price hikes. Also true is the fact that, like with the rest of the market, earbuds are a dime a dozen, and brands have to find a way to position their product apart from others. The recently launched CMF Buds Neo's design stood out in our first impressions piece. And on paper, it has interesting features like 35dB Active Noise Cancellation, a 12.4mm dynamic driver, Bluetooth 6.0, and a long battery life claim. The asking price is Rs 2,199, and after using it for weeks, including a long train journey to Kerala and back, I have more thoughts to share. Read on to know how these features come together in daily use in our CMF Buds Neo review.



EASY FIT AND FUN DESIGN SUITED FOR LONG LISTENING

I have already spoken about the CMF Buds Neo's square case, circular dial, and overall design in my first impressions, so I won't repeat that here. However, after spending more time with them, there are a few practical aspects of the design worth talking about.

Because of its light and compact build, the case was easy to carry around in pockets and handbags. It was comfortable to hold in my palm, and the mechanical dial was fun to fidget with whenever I was anxious. The earbuds were also easy on the ears, even for extended periods of listening. I had it in my ears for most of my three-day, somewhat jerky train journey, and the thing securely sat there. It offered a good seal from outside commotion.

The touch gestures were thankfully responsive. If they hadn't been, that would've irked me more than I was already sitting in crammed train seats.

Having IP54 dust and splash resistance was reassuring during the occasional drizzles in Kerala. It allowed me to continue wearing the earbuds and listening to music. Well, who would want to stop 'I Think I Like When It Rains' by WILLIS while it's raining? Though I was a little apprehensive about taking the IPX2-rated Buds Neo case to the beach, nothing happened. Just know the case offers inferior water resistance and no dust resistance.

BASS FIRST, ENERGETIC, AND CUSTOMISABLE SOUND

The CMF Buds Neo's 12.4mm dynamic driver produces a warm and energetic sound. You feel the buds' lower-end preference right away. The opening beat of I Think I Like When It Rains is heavier on this one than on our reference device. And this bassiness stays throughout the track. It doesn't feel distasteful to me and is something I come to expect from buds of its ilk. You can turn off the default bass enhancement or choose a different equaliser mode if you prefer less bass.

Even with the default Immersion Boost equaliser and its bassiness, the vocals were reasonably clear. So, you can enjoy a lot of Bollywood or pop tracks like C.R.E.A.M POSSE by Baggh-e SMG; where the voices of all singers were strong and present.

The bass does not completely overwhelm the rest of the sound, though. Vocals remain reasonably clear, which is important because a bass-heavy tuning can otherwise make singers sound distant or muffled.

Our internal frequency response measurements echo this Buds Neo behaviour: Elevated bass, giving drums and basslines plenty of weight. Vocals have decent emphasis while not being hefty, and the treble portion is rolled off to take some of the crispiness and sparkle from the cymbals in tracks like Kiliye from ARM (2024) and The Little Things Give You Away by Linkin Park.

The sound isn't neutral, but not dull either. The bass-forward treatment is good to hear, with ample presence for vocals and most instruments.

The Spatial Audio mode extends the soundstage. However, the widened presentation isn't something that I would miss if I turn it off or switch to a different pair of earbuds.

ANC AND TRANSPARENCY MODES ARE USEFUL

The CMF Buds Neo offer up to 35dB of adaptive ANC, with three levels and an Adaptive mode. I kept it on High mode only. It doesn't make every background noise disappear, but it and the passive isolation from the eartips' seal gave me some peace during what was an otherwise noisy train travel.

Sometimes, I would use the Transparency mode to be aware of my surroundings. Of course, with the music